

Courtship as a Straight Male in Contemporary India

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Abstract

This paper examines the multifaceted experience of heterosexual men in urban India who are post-college, professionally active, and seeking marriage. It integrates evolutionary psychology, sexual script theory, sociocultural analyses of Indian marriage paradigms, and personal-reflective insights, illustrated with anonymized anecdotal narratives. The discussion emphasizes strategic positioning, emotional vulnerability, and long-term vision for sustainable marital and sexual satisfaction, while acknowledging feminist critiques, intersectional limitations, and women's perspectives. Anecdotes are illustrative, collected informally; future empirical research with broader sampling is suggested.

Preface

This paper draws on the author's perspective as a cisgender heterosexual man, supplemented with anonymized anecdotes from men and women in urban India (e.g., Mumbai, Bangalore, Delhi). While not claiming representativeness, it aims for respectful inclusivity and invites future research to broaden perspectives. The anecdotes presented here were gathered through informal conversations and are used illustratively; they are not part of a formal systematic study. A brief reflection on potential biases (e.g., urban, English-speaking circles; class; caste; religion; sexual orientation) is added in the Limitations section.

1 Introduction

In contemporary urban India—cities such as Mumbai, Bangalore, and Delhi—educated, employed men in their mid-20s to early 30s navigate a complex courtship terrain where arranged-marriage traditions coexist with rising aspirations for love, compatibility, and digital-age interactions. This paper, grounded in my own reflections and supplemented by anonymized anecdotal narratives from peers, explores this landscape by integrating

evolutionary psychology, sexual script theory, and sociocultural analysis. It also incorporates feminist critiques and intersectional awareness to avoid reductive or transactional framings. While the focus remains on heterosexual male experiences, selected women’s perspectives are included to enrich understanding of mutual dynamics.

2 Methods: Anecdotal Narrative Collection

Given resource constraints and the reflective nature of this work, the “data” consist of informal, anonymized conversations with peers (approximately 6 men and 4 women) in urban Indian contexts between 2023 and 2025. No formal institutional review was sought, as these were casual, voluntary exchanges among acquaintances; all names and identifying details have been changed. The aim is illustrative: to ground theoretical discussion in lived scenarios. Future work should formalize these into systematic qualitative interviews or surveys with stratified sampling across regions, socio-economic strata, caste groups, languages, and gender/sexual orientations.

3 Literature Review

3.1 Evolutionary Foundations of Male Mating Strategies

Evolutionary psychology suggests sex-differentiated mating strategies shaped by ancestral adaptive pressures. Men’s long-term mating priorities include cues of fidelity and compatibility; short-term contexts emphasize fertility indicators (Buss, 1989; Buss and Schmitt, 1993; Confer, Perilloux, and Buss, 2010). Emotional responses like jealousy also differ by sex in predictable ways (Buss, 1989). These frameworks offer a lens but must be tempered with cultural specificities and critiques¹.

3.2 Sexual Economics and Feminist Critiques

The sexual economics framework describes sex as a resource in social markets, portraying men often as resource-offerers and women as resource-holders (Baumeister and Vohs, 2004). However, feminist scholars critique transactional metaphors for risking reduction of human agency and ignoring power imbalances (Rubin, 1984). This paper acknowledges those critiques, emphasizing authenticity, consent, and mutual respect rather than viewing interactions purely in market terms. Cultural norms in India (family approval, reputation, norms around chastity) further modulate perceived “costs” and “benefits” in

¹Evolutionary models provide hypotheses about broad patterns but can underplay cultural, structural, and individual variation; see feminist and cultural critiques of universalizing tendencies.

courtship (Kaustav, 2003; Shakir and Yuvaraj, 2024)².

3.3 Sexual Script Theory

Sexual script theory posits that sexual and courtship behaviors follow culturally learned “scripts” guiding interpretations of desire, approaches to interaction, and transitions to intimacy (Gagnon and Simon, 1973). In India, traditional scripts (modesty, family-involved matchmaking) intersect with digital-age scripts (online messaging, social media) to form hybrid patterns. Navigating these scripts requires decoding implicit signals and adapting approaches to avoid misinterpretation or backlash. This blend of old and new “scripts” is dynamic and varies by urban/rural, community norms, and individual backgrounds.

3.4 Indian Marriage Paradigms: Arranged, Love, and Hybrids

Arranged marriages remain predominant in many settings (often cited 90–95%), yet urban youth increasingly blend individual choice with familial input, yielding “love-arranged” hybrids (Netting, 2010; Reed, 2025). Ethnographies highlight how educated professionals reconceptualize intimacy, equality, and autonomy while respecting kinship norms. The ideoscape of romantic love meets deep-rooted family expectations, prompting creative courtship strategies. For instance, “roka” engagements may serve as a sanctioned period for premarital courtship within an arranged-marriage framework (Reed, 2025)³. Recent studies document the rise of dating apps usage and “semi-arranged” practices in urban India, filtered through caste/gender hierarchies and family oversight (Nikhat and Shukla, 2025)⁴.

4 The Psychology of Initiation: Strategy and Vulnerability

4.1 The Double Bind of Male Initiation

Despite evolving norms toward gender parity, men often carry the expectation of initiating romantic contact. Direct compliments—especially physical ones—may risk misinterpretation or reputational harm in digital contexts (e.g., screenshots). Thus, men must balance honesty with subtlety: express appreciation for intellectual or value-based qualities (e.g.,

²Shakir & Yuvaraj (2024) study South Indian adults’ sexual attitudes, but more regionally diverse, recent work is needed.

³Roka engagements formalize a match but allow exploratory courtship, reflecting hybridization; see Reed (2025), based on urban Delhi data.

⁴E.g., Nikhat & Shukla (2025) on changing dating patterns; Rajadesingan et al. (2019) on caste attitudes in matrimonial profiles; Mondal et al. (2023) on disclosure norms online highlight socio-cultural layers.

“I admired your insights on X”) rather than focusing solely on appearance, akin to a respectful “cold email” in professional life (Baumeister and Vohs, 2004).

4.2 Real-Life Narrative: Case Study – Aarav (28, Bengaluru)

Aarav, a marketing professional, noticed a colleague Priya’s insightful comments in team discussions. He crafted a message:

“Hi Priya, I appreciated your perspective in yesterday’s marketing meeting about consumer psychology. I’d love to discuss brand storytelling further over coffee, if you’re open to it.”

This approach complimented competence rather than appearance, signaled genuine interest in her intellect, and respected boundaries. Priya responded positively; they dated for six months before amicably parting ways. This illustrates positioning oneself by highlighting shared interests and respecting professional context.

4.3 Positioning and Emotional Framing

Positioning involves presenting one’s attributes (education, stability, values) aligned with a prospective partner’s preferences, authentically. Emotional framing means conveying genuine curiosity and respect without desperation⁵. For instance:

“Hi [Name], I saw your post on [topic]; your perspective on [specific point] resonated with me. I’d value discussing [shared interest] further—perhaps over coffee or a call, if you’re open to it.”

This signals respect for intellect and time, indicates intent for deeper connection, and avoids immediate romantic pressure.

4.4 Navigating Digital Platforms

Platforms like matrimonial sites, social media, or professional networks require platform-appropriate norms.

- **Matrimonial Sites:** Explicit intent for marriage is acceptable. Sincerity and specificity—e.g., “seeking a partnership grounded in mutual growth, emotional honesty, and healthy intimacy”—help filter compatible prospects.
- **Professional Networks (e.g., LinkedIn):** Initial contact around professional interests before gently exploring personal compatibility ensures respect and clear boundaries.

⁵Overt eagerness can signal low selectivity; too detached an approach can signal indifference. Balance is key.

- **Social Media:** Public interactions (likes, comments) should be respectful and low-pressure; direct messaging should reference shared interests or contexts.

Anecdote – Rohit (31, Mumbai): On a matrimonial site, Rohit’s profile stated: “Looking for a partnership rooted in mutual growth, emotional openness, and shared sense of humor.” He included hobbies (weekend hikes). Within weeks, two matches messaged about hiking—demonstrating how specificity filters well.

5 Handling Rejection and Emotional Resilience

5.1 Anticipating and Normalizing Rejection

High-value prospects often receive many approaches; rejection is common. Recognizing this as normal reduces emotional distress. Each rejection can offer lessons: reflect on message clarity, tone, or profile alignment rather than internalizing as personal failure. Over time, this builds resilience (Buss, 1989).

5.2 Mini-Case: Rejection Reflection – Vishal (27, Pune)

After two declines via WhatsApp, Vishal spent a week reflecting. He realized his messages were generic (“Hi, you seem nice—coffee?”) and refined his approach to reference specific interests from the person’s profile. On his third attempt, he received a positive response. This illustrates how reflection and adaptation improve outcomes.

5.3 Cultivating Vulnerability Safely

While resilience is key, connection also requires measured vulnerability: sharing personal values, aspirations, and emotional goals in incremental steps. Oversharing early can backfire; undersharing can signal detachment. A phased disclosure approach—initial rapport via shared interests, then deeper topics (life vision, marriage expectations)—when mutual comfort is established, is advisable.

6 Building Shared Vision Before Commitment

6.1 Clarifying Personal Values and Boundaries

Before deepening a relationship, introspect on:

- Desired marital dynamics (decision-making style, family involvement, work–life balance).
- Sexual expectations: frequency, openness to experimentation, handling mismatches.

- Financial philosophies: saving, spending, joint vs. separate accounts.
- Family planning: timeline, parenting styles, roles.

Clarity helps steer conversations with prospective partners, ensuring alignment over critical life domains (Fisher, 1992).

6.2 Practical Dialogue Example

Man: “I believe discussions around finances help build trust—how comfortable are you talking about budgets, saving goals, that sort of thing?”

Partner: “I’m open. I’d prefer joint accounts for essentials and separate pocket money accounts.”

Early conversations like this align financial philosophies before deeper commitment.

6.3 Gradual Introduction of Marital Intent

Transitioning from casual chat to marriage-intent discussion can follow a sequence:

1. Shared values conversation (e.g., “What do you value most in life partnerships?”).
2. Future aspirations (career goals, living preferences, family importance).
3. Views on marriage form: love marriage, arranged, or hybrid⁶.
4. Timeline considerations: readiness, family expectations.
5. Sexual compatibility discussion: respectfully, e.g., “I value a fulfilling intimate life—how do you view communication around sexual needs within a committed relationship?”

Calibrate by mutual comfort and context (in-person vs. digital). Including women’s perspectives here can ensure the discussion is two-sided.

7 Sexual Connection in a Dignified Manner

7.1 Framing Sexual Topics Respectfully

Discussing sex pre-marriage requires sensitivity: cultural taboos, personal comfort levels, and privacy. Frame it in terms of mutual well-being and future marital health:

“I believe sexual compatibility is important in long-term relationships; open dialogue about needs, consent, and comfort zones fosters trust. How do you view communication around intimacy in a committed relationship?”

This normalizes the topic as part of holistic compatibility rather than crude objectification.

⁶Hybrid forms may involve family introductions after initial mutual choice, or roka engagements that formalize intent while allowing premarital courtship.

7.2 Anecdote + Women’s Perspective

Sara’s View (Woman, 30, HR professional):

“When a man says, ‘I think sexual compatibility matters—can we talk about physical boundaries?’ I appreciate that he’s taking my comfort seriously. It shows maturity and respect.”

This aligns with feminist critiques: it is not transactional bargaining but co-creating respectful dialogue (Rubin, 1984; Gagnon and Simon, 1973).

7.3 Sexual Psychology Perspectives

Drawing on sexual script theory (Gagnon and Simon, 1973) and evolutionary insights (Buss and Schmitt, 1993), one can anticipate that initial sexual hesitancy is normal, planning for gradual exploration after trust-building. Discussing such topics signals maturity and foresight.

7.4 Managing Health and Practical Considerations

Openly addressing sexual health (e.g., STI awareness, contraception plans) conveys responsibility. In contexts where premarital sexual discussions may be sensitive, frame in terms of future marital health:

“For our future, I consider sexual health vital; how do you view discussions around testing and mutual safety?”

This aligns with responsible partner norms and reduces future conflicts.

8 Post-Marriage Dynamics: Ongoing Negotiation

8.1 Emotional and Sexual Maintenance

Marriage is not an endpoint but a new phase requiring ongoing negotiation:

- Regular check-ins on emotional needs.
- Evolving sexual desires; adapting over time.
- Managing external stressors (work, family) and protecting couple time.
- Conflict resolution: developing fair processes for disagreements.

Failure to address sexual mismatches or emotional drift can lead to dissatisfaction. Quality interaction studies support proactive communication (Netting, 2010).

8.2 Real-Life Couple: Rohan & Meera (Married 2 Years, Delhi)

Rohan and Meera schedule monthly “check-ins” to discuss emotional needs, career stress, and intimacy. They report high satisfaction due to proactive communication. This exemplifies iterative negotiation benefiting marital resilience.

8.3 Strategic Adaptation and Growth

Just as courtship involved strategy and learning, marriage benefits from strategic planning: joint goal-setting (financial, parenting, lifestyle), anticipating life transitions (children, career changes), and renegotiating roles. This “iterative collaboration” contrasts with passive assumptions that “marriage solves everything” (Baumeister and Vohs, 2004).

9 Limitations and Intersectional Reflections

Although this paper acknowledges its anecdotal and informal basis, it is important to reflect on potential biases:

- **Urban, English-speaking milieu:** Anecdotes stem from metropolitan professionals comfortable in English; rural, vernacular contexts may differ markedly.
- **Class and Education:** Participants are largely from middle/upper-middle socioeconomic strata; experiences of less privileged men/women may involve different pressures (economic urgency, limited autonomy).
- **Caste and Religion:** Caste norms (endogamy pressures, inter-caste attitudes) and religious prescriptions vary across communities; courtship strategies must account for these layers.
- **Gender and Sexual Orientation:** Focus is on cis-heterosexual men; LGBTQ+ experiences and women-led initiation dynamics are beyond this scope but crucial for broader understanding.
- **Digital Divide:** Reliance on online platforms assumes smartphone/internet access; many still rely primarily on family networks or matchmakers.
- **Self-Selection and Recall Bias:** Anonymized casual conversations may reflect selective memories and social desirability.

Future systematic research should sample across regions (North, South, East, West), languages, socioeconomic strata, caste/religious groups, and include diverse gender/sexual orientations to map the full spectrum of courtship practices.

10 Discussion

The integrative analysis, supported by anonymized anecdotal narratives and enriched with recent India-specific studies, highlights that for modern urban Indian men (and by extension similar contexts), successful mate pursuit involves:

- **Strategic positioning:** Presenting one’s attributes aligned with partner preferences, through respectful and context-appropriate initiation.
- **Emotional intelligence:** Balancing resilience against rejection with measured vulnerability to build trust.
- **Cultural navigation:** Understanding traditional scripts (arranged norms) and new scripts (digital interactions, individual choice), including hybrid forms like roka engagements (Reed, 2025).
- **Intersectional awareness:** Recognizing how class, caste, religion, and regional norms shape possibilities and constraints in courtship.
- **Long-term vision:** Clarifying values around marriage, sexual life, family planning, and aligning gradually rather than rushing.
- **Ongoing negotiation:** Treating marriage as a dynamic process requiring continual dialogue on emotional and sexual domains.

By weaving personal narrative and anecdotal evidence into established theory and recent empirical findings from India, this paper deepens academic legitimacy and practical value. Incorporating feminist critiques and selected women’s perspectives avoids unilateral strategizing and underscores co-creation of healthy relationships. The anecdotes are illustrative; systematic qualitative or mixed-methods research with broader, stratified sampling could build on these insights, exploring, for example, rural–urban contrasts, caste dynamics, or platform-mediated biases (Nikhat and Shukla, 2025; ?).

11 Conclusion and Future Directions

Heterosexual men seeking marriage in contemporary urban India face a nuanced interplay of evolutionary predispositions, cultural expectations, and personal aspirations. Approaching courtship with strategic respect, emotional maturity, intersectional awareness, and clear long-term planning increases the likelihood of aligning with a compatible partner. Sustaining marital and sexual satisfaction demands ongoing negotiation, adaptability, and open communication. Integrating psychological frameworks with reflective practice and illustrative anecdotes—while acknowledging feminist critiques, intersectional complexities, and women’s voices—provides a more holistic guide for navigating the complex journey from pre-dating through marriage and beyond, preserving dignity, mutual respect, and enduring connection.

Future research directions:

- **Systematic qualitative interviews** across varied urban/rural and cultural settings to map diverse courtship experiences.
- **Survey-based studies** measuring prevalence of different initiation strategies, digital platform usage, and attitudes toward hybrid marriage forms.
- **Longitudinal designs** following couples from initiation through early marriage to identify predictors of satisfaction and resilience.
- **Intersectional analyses** focusing on caste, class, religion, and sexual orientation to reveal differential constraints and opportunities.
- **Platform algorithm studies** to examine biases in dating app recommendations, and implications for mate access (Kalra et al., 2023).

Such work can inform not only individual strategies but also policy discussions (e.g., digital literacy, mental health support) and platform design (inclusive matching algorithms), contributing to healthier relational outcomes in India’s evolving sociocultural milieu.

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⁷The Kama Sutra (2nd–3rd century CE) is an ancient text on erotic love, courtship, and marital dynamics, emphasizing emotional aspects and social etiquette beyond mere descriptions of sexual positions.